CHAPTER 10

REBELS AND THE RAJ

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master the 1857 Revolt: mutiny turning into popular rebellion, greased cartridges catalyst, Awadh annexation grievance ('cherry in mouth'), leadership (Bahadur Shah, Rani Lakshmibai, Kunwar Singh), and colonial counter-insurgency.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Ignition and Spread of Mutiny:** Began at Meerut on 10 May 1857; sepoys marched to Delhi, capturing the Red Fort and compelling Bahadur Shah Zafar to accept nominal leadership; mutiny quickly transformed into a civil rebellion.

• **Underlying Causes and Awadh Annexation:** Enfield greased cartridges offended Hindu and Muslim religious taboos; Lord Dalhousie annexed Awadh in 1856 on pretext of misgovernance ('a cherry that will drop into our mouth one day'), dispossessing taluqdars and sepoys ('nursery of the Bengal Army').

• **Unity, Visions, and Proclamations:** Rebels issued secular proclamations (Azamgarh Proclamation 1857) appealing to both Hindus and Muslims; rejected British racial hierarchy, destroyed colonial records, and established provisional administrations.

• **Suppression and Visual Representation:** British launched brutal counter-insurgency reconquering Delhi (Sept 1857) and Lucknow (1858); British visual art celebrated imperial retribution (Barker's Relief of Lucknow) while Indian memory celebrated martyrdom (Rani Lakshmibai).

ESSENTIAL HISTORICAL CHRONOLOGIES & THEMES

$$\text{1857 Outbreak Arc} \iff \text{Meerut Sepoy Mutiny (May 10)} \to \text{Delhi Proclamation of Bahadur Shah} \to \text{Pan-Gangetic Rebellion}$$

Sequential Expansion of the Anti-Colonial Uprising

$$\text{Awadh Grievance Nexus} \iff \text{Annexation (1856)} + \text{Dispossessed Taluqdars} + \text{Sepoy Kinship Grievance}$$

Catalytic Ground of Mass Revolt in Central Northern India

$$\text{Rebel Leadership Matrix} \to \{\text{Delhi: Bahadur Shah, Kanpur: Nana Sahib, Jhansi: Lakshmibai, Arrah: Kunwar Singh}\}$$

Polycentric Regional Leadership Configuration

$$\text{Government of India Act 1858} \iff \text{Abolition of East India Company} \to \text{Direct Crown Rule Under Queen Victoria}$$

Structural Transformation of Colonial Imperial State

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Awadh was described by Lord Dalhousie in 1851 as 'a cherry that will drop into our mouth one day'; it was formally annexed in 1856 by deposing Nawab Wajid Ali Shah.

• **Alert:** The 1857 revolt witnessed remarkable Hindu-Muslim harmony; British attempts to incite communal divisions failed, and the cow slaughter ban was respected by rebels.

• **Alert:** Never describe 1857 merely as a 'Sepoy Mutiny'; once civilian taluqdars, peasants, artisans, and religious mendicants joined, it became a massive popular war of liberation.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Explain the major causes responsible for the Revolt of 1857. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **1. Military Discontent:** Indian sepoys faced racial discrimination, lower salaries, lack of promotion opportunities, and were denied foreign service allowances (batta). **[1 Mark]**

• **2. Immediate Cause (Greased Cartridges):** Introduction of the new Enfield rifle whose cartridges were greased with cow and pig fat, deeply offending religious beliefs of Hindu and Muslim soldiers. **[1 Mark]**

• **3. Annexation of Princely States:** Lord Dalhousie's aggressive Doctrine of Lapse (Jhansi, Satara, Nagpur) and the arbitrary annexation of Awadh in 1856 dispossessed hereditary ruling families. **[1 Mark]**

• **4. Agrarian and Economic Ruin:** Heavy colonial land revenue settlements dispossessed taluqdars, impoverished peasants, and ruined traditional weavers through imported British mill cloth. **[1 Mark]**

2. Why was Awadh described as the 'Nursery of the Bengal Army'? How did its annexation catalyze the 1857 revolt? [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Nursery of Bengal Army:** For decades, the British recruited heavily from Awadh; almost every peasant household had at least one member serving in the Bengal Army (over 75,000 sepoys were from Awadh). **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Impact of Annexation (1856):** Deposition of Nawab Wajid Ali Shah caused widespread cultural and emotional grief; the Summary Settlement of 1856 dispossessed taluqdars of nearly half their villages. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Sepoy Radicalization:** Sepoys felt the insult to their king and their families' increased land tax burdens directly, turning Awadh into the fiercest hotbed of popular resistance in 1857. **[1 Mark]**

3. Mention three regional leaders of the 1857 Revolt and the regions they led. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **1. Rani Lakshmibai (Jhansi):** Led the heroic defence of Jhansi and fought fiercely in battle alongside Tatya Tope. **[1 Mark]**

• **2. Nana Sahib (Kanpur):** Adopted son of the last Peshwa Baji Rao II who established rebel administration in Kanpur. **[1 Mark]**

• **3. Kunwar Singh (Arrah in Bihar):** An elderly zamindar of Jagdishpur who led guerrilla resistance against British troops across western Bihar. **[1 Mark]**

4. Discuss the evidence demonstrating communal harmony between Hindus and Muslims during the 1857 Revolt. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Unanimous Acceptance of Emperor:** Hindu and Muslim sepoys and commanders alike rallied around Mughal Emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar as the supreme legitimate sovereign of India. **[1 Mark]**

• **Secular Proclamations:** Proclamations like the Azamgarh Proclamation of August 1857 addressed both communities equally, invoking Hindu and Muslim shared heritage. **[1 Mark]**

• **Mutual Respect:** Rebels banned cow slaughter in Delhi and Lucknow to respect Hindu religious sentiments; British attempts to finance communal riots in Bareilly completely failed. **[1 Mark]**

5. How did British visual representations portray the suppression of the 1857 Revolt? Give one example. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Nature of Imagery:** Painted by British artists to celebrate military heroism, justify brutal retributive violence, and glorify British invincibility for audiences at home. **[1 Mark]**

• **Example:** Thomas Jones Barker's celebrated canvas 'Relief of Lucknow' (1859), depicting the triumphant meeting of Campbell, Outram, and Havelock amidst wounded soldiers. **[1 Mark]**

6. What major administrative change was introduced in India by the British Parliament in 1858 following the Revolt? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Government of India Act 1858:** Abolished the rule of the English East India Company and transferred the direct sovereign governance of India to the British Crown under Queen Victoria, creating the office of Secretary of State and Viceroy. **[2 Marks]**